

Images Courtesy JOFRE OLIVERAS/GALLERY XXL





Images Courtesy SAJID WAJID SHAIKH/GALLERY XXL



« **HISTORY REVISITED** (Clockwise from right) Sajid Wajid Shaikh's 'Ghar'—hand carvings on found white granite; the 'Digital Ruin' (smartphone) series, and The Fall (oil on canvas) by Jofre Oliveras

ART

FRAGMENTED **RUINS**

A new exhibition at **Gallery XXL, Mumbai** juxtaposes the artworks of an Indian and a Spanish artist

Chunks of white granite stand on black columns, almost reminiscent of historical fragments displayed in archaeological museums worldwide. Instead of ancient engravings, these blocks feature hand carvings of houses, geometrical shapes with a depth of field. 'Ghar' (written in Devanagari script) reads the accompanying placard, ruminating on the illusion of home and how houses made of brick and mortar embody one's existence and memories. Elsewhere, oil paintings on wood or aluminium rendered in the scale of a smartphone depict incredibly detailed bird's-eye views of some of the most evocative ruins in the world—from Mohenjo-daro and Hampi to the Parthenon and Colosseum. A common thread runs between the two exhibits, the former presented by Indian artist Sajid Wajid Shaikh and the latter by Spanish artist Jofre Oliveras. Currently on view at Gallery XXL, Mumbai, *Witness and Evidence: deliberations on ruins by Sajid Wajid Shaikh and Jofre Oliveras* is an investigation of the ruins that are around us, and the ruins that are far away but continue to surround us.

SHAIKH AND OLIVERAS are guided by different artistic expressions rooted in their respective cultures, but 'their works seem to speak together'

Shaikh, a Mumbai-based multidisciplinary artist, and Spanish muralist and painter Oliveras from Girona come from different backgrounds and are guided by different artistic expressions rooted in their respective cultures. "When we were studying the two artists and their processes, we realised that their works seemed to speak together, without the artists ever knowing each other. We saw the idea of ruins as a commonality with both artists' take on it and that's how the show came together," says gallery director Joe Cyril. The works on display, most of which have been created for this particular exhibition, invite the viewer to deliberate upon confusions that emerge from witnessing ruins and explore historical losses that seek preservation.

Shaikh's sculptures made of marble and concrete evoke resilience in materialities, while his observational drawings and found objects invite contemplation on the idea of home. In relation to this, Oliveras' works—whose imagination of digital objects takes physical forms with traditional materials—transport the viewer to the ruins we might encounter in future. Apart from the aforementioned 'Digital Ruin' (smartphone) series, 'The Fall' features (in oil on canvas) classical Greek and Roman busts that serve as a metaphor for the complexities of the present world. Neither artist shies away from the realities of conflict, whether it's the current wars or caste and religion-based violence. "After all, it's war and conflict that create the next set of ruins," says Cyril. ■

–Prachi Joshi

The exhibition is on view until June 29. It will be complemented by a weekly programming calendar of artist talks, film screenings, and topical walks (schedule posted on Instagram; @xxl.gallery).